way to Kandahar. This was the next stage in his mission where he was to negotiate a treaty with Dost Mohammad's Barakzai half-brothers who, having been rejected by Auckland, had now also agreed to join Dost Mohammad, the Persians and the Russians in the siege of Herat.

Herat was Vitkevitch's final Afghan destination. He was accompanied there by Barakzai princes from both Kabul and Kandahar, and was received in triumph in the Persian camp by Count Simonitch on 9 June. Vitkevitch had achieved more for Russia than any of his superiors had even dared hope. His triumph over Burnes and the British was total.[105] Shortly afterwards the Shah of Persia invested him with Order of the Lion and the Sun.[106]

Burnes by then was back in Peshawar, awaiting further instructions. Meanwhile he vented his frustration to Major Holland. 'The game is up,' he wrote. 'The Russians gave me the coup de grâce and I could hold no longer at Kabul so I have fallen back on Peshawar. Our government would do nothing and the Russian legation came down with the most direct offers of assistance and money, and as I had no power to counter act him by a similar offer I was obliged of course to give in.'[107]

His public letters to Simla were, however, more diplomatic. Burnes realised that ironically the failure of his mission meant that the need for an Afghan expert was now greater than ever. He knew that war with Kabul was now possible, perhaps even probable, and despite all his misgivings about the direction British policy was taking, he was sufficiently ambitious still to want to be at the helm of whatever it was that Lord Auckland now had planned.

Even before Burnes reached Peshawar, the wheels of the Company machine were cranking into action to demonise Dost Mohammad and punish him for what Auckland interpreted as his defiance. 'Dost Mahomed Khan has shewn himself to be so disaffected and ambitious that with him we could form no satisfactory connection,' Auckland reported, most inaccurately, to London.[108] If the Amir would not co-operate with Auckland's wishes, then he clearly needed to be replaced by Shah Shuja, who Auckland believed would be more reasonable and do as he was told. But exactly how this was to happen, and in what form, Auckland had yet to decide.